relieving student stress, from shaking errant bureaucrats out of their slumber to ticking off errant BJP MPs and coaching partymen about what messages to carry to the people, he does it all—and incessantly. Of course, a lot of this also has to do with the fact that the BJP is already remounting its election army to ready for 2024. No Indian prime minister has won three elections on the trot except, again, Nehru.

Exam-bound students are a critical sector here—a most desirable audience for Modi's classroom since a good many of them will be first-time voters in '24. Government data shows 11.4 million tuned in live to Pariksha Pe Charcha via various digital platforms. This is excluding schoolkids in the countryside who watched it live on TV. Besides alleviating students' exam stress, experts believe the BJP is building up a legacy for Modi, enhancing the political brand value of their most valuable icon amongst an all-new constituency. The vibe he adopts isn't headmasterly but collegial. In the latest edition, the PM talked about some of the reformist features of the New Education Policy—like extending credits to sports activities and skills. His sessions with sportspersons and movie stars does no harm to his connect with the younger lot either. In 2019, 5 per cent of the voters were first-timers. BJP leaders are loath to link Pariksha Pe Charcha to politics, but do admit it adds to the overall Modi brand value.

MODI SUTRAS

BUZZWORDS FOR BABUS

- The need of the hour is big ideas. Development goals can only be achieved this way
- Be proactive in suggesting policy improvements
- Jobs are a key focus area. Look for avenues to increase employment opportunities

MANTRAS FOR MPS

- Elected MPs must ensure smooth implementation of central schemes
- The pandemic is not over yet, MPs must closely monitor Covid relief
- MPs are representatives of the public. It's important to have a strong social media presence and effectively use it for delivery of public good
- Party MPs must lead the fight against opposition-ruled governments in their states

LESSONS FOR SCHOOLKIDS / PARENTS

- Students must identify their own strengths and interests, and define their ambitions accordingly
- Exams are a part of one's life. At many stages, one will be tested. Try to be exam-proof, celebrate it as a festival
- Parents mustn't force their dreams, ambitions on children



THE MENTOR PM
File picture of PM Modi addressing new IAS recruits

In all his years in office, the PM has never been shy of deploying his best weapon—his natural oratory—to good use, whether for direct political messaging or otherwise. After this year's budget, Modi did a townhall with partymen on its highlights. Again, this was in hybrid mode—he addressed a physical audience at the party HQ in Delhi, the rest tuned in digitally. Another session, on April 6, saw him elaborate on his vision of the party's trajectory. At a more micro level, Modi has also been tutoring partymen back home in Gujarat to prep them for the assembly poll at the year-end. The 'tuitions' essentially contain talking points on how to communicate the party's agenda to the people, and why party cadre must not get complacent.

Meanwhile, on April 3, he held a session with bureaucrats from several central ministries where, again, he reiterated the need to come up with big ideas for development, job creation and policy improvements. This is an annual session with the bureaucracy which the PM has been hosting since 2014, where he allows free and frank discussions.

Curiosity levels have also been high about his 'Breakfast Pe Charchas' with groups of BJP MPs from states like Rajasthan, Jharkhand, Bihar, West Bengal and Madhya Pradesh. Those who attended the meetings in New Delhi during both halves of the budget session say the prime minister kept asking about the work done in their respective constituencies for Covid relief, implementation of central schemes, the social media presence of the MPs and much else. "In fact, PM Modi ticked off many of the MPs for non-performance," says an attendee. The MPs, of course, realise that many of them won because of Modi's appeal among the masses. The PM also reportedly asked some of the senior MPs why they weren't speaking more vociferously against their home state governments (most of the attending MPs were from opposition-ruled states). Makes excellent sense, of course. With assembly polls coming up in Gujarat and Karnataka, followed by Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh and Chhattisgarh, the BJP's numero uno isn't leaving anything to chance. ■